

Tower of London - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

The White Tower: Architecture as Intimidation

The White Tower is the building that gives the fortress its name, begun around 1078 for William the Conqueror. It's worth pausing on what it meant. A decade after Hastings, London was the largest, richest, most independent-minded city in William's new kingdom, and he answered it with the largest secular building project England had seen since Rome — a keep of pale Caen limestone, shipped from Normandy, rising thirty meters over a city of timber and thatch. It was never primarily about defense; it was about legibility. Every Londoner who looked east saw Norman permanence. The building is remarkably intact: the Chapel of St John on the second floor is one of the best-preserved pieces of early Norman architecture anywhere, austere and barrel-vaulted, essentially unchanged since the 1080s. The Tower went on to be whatever the Crown needed — royal residence, arsenal, treasury, the Royal Mint for five hundred years, record office, menagerie, and prison. Its last prisoner is more recent than you'd guess: Rudolf Hess, Hitler's deputy, was held here briefly in 1941, and the Kray twins were detained here in 1952 while dodging national service. Inside, the Royal Armouries' Line of Kings is arguably the world's oldest museum exhibit, delighting tourists since the 1680s.

Related listening: 1066 joins them: the Viking Age ended near York the same year the Conqueror's Tower story began. Coming up — “1066: The Viking Age Ends Just Up the Road” (JORVIK & Viking York, Day 14).

Why the White Tower Is White

The name is more literal than most visitors assume. In 1240 Henry the Third ordered the great keep whitened, inside and out, with lime wash, and the effect must have been startling. A vast pale block, thirty meters high, glowing above a city of timber and smoke. Henry was following a European fashion for painting prestige buildings brilliant white, and though the coating has long since weathered off, the name outlived the paint. You are looking, in effect, at a medieval billboard that has forgotten its own slogan.

Study the silhouette. Four turrets crown the corners, three of them square and one, at the north-east, round, because it encloses the main spiral stair. That round turret has an afterlife worth knowing. In the sixteen-seventies the first Astronomer Royal, John Flamsteed, set up to observe the heavens from it, before the smoke and the ravens drove the observatory downriver to Greenwich, where it gave its name to Greenwich Mean Time. The gilded weathervanes are Restoration additions. The whole roofline you see is a later reconstruction, but the mass beneath it is authentically Norman.

Notice the architecture of intimidation in the details. The walls batter, meaning they taper inward as they climb, which reads as sheer immovable weight. At the base they splay into a plinth, a defensive slope that turned anything dropped from the parapet into a ricocheting missile aimed outward. And the fabric is a palimpsest of maintenance. The original Caen limestone from Normandy weathers poorly in the English climate, so since at least the seventeenth century it has been progressively refaced, much of it in harder Portland stone, the very stone Wren was using across the river for Saint Paul's. Christopher Wren himself

had a hand in remodeling the Tower's windows, enlarging them from arrow-slit meanness into something a Restoration court could live behind.

So the building rewards a slow eye. Its whiteness is a lost paint job, its round turret an early observatory, its very stones a thousand-year argument between French ambition and English weather. Almost nothing about the surface is original, and yet the thing itself, the sheer Norman idea of it, has never moved an inch.

The Line of Kings and the King's Armour

Inside the White Tower you can visit what has a fair claim to be the oldest museum display on earth. The Line of Kings has been drawing paying visitors since at least the sixteen-eighties, which makes the Royal Armouries, its parent collection, Britain's oldest national museum. The seventeenth-century original was gloriously bogus and gloriously popular, a procession of carved wooden horses bearing the armours of England's kings, arranged to advertise an ancient, unbroken royal succession, several of the attributions cheerfully invented. Some of those magnificent horses survive and are around three hundred and twenty-five years old. Look for the baroque carving, once optimistically credited to the workshop of Grinling Gibbons.

The centerpiece, then and now, is Henry the Eighth. The Tower holds his field and tournament armour of about 1540, made at the royal workshop at Greenwich, and it is a portrait in steel of a man who by then was enormous, chest and waist well over fifty inches, an athlete gone to seed but still radiating menace. What everyone remembers is the codpiece, a jutting, unmissable steel projection that was pure Tudor political theater, broadcasting the king's virility and, by implication, his fitness to father a dynasty, the very thing that dominated and destabilized his entire reign.

There is a footnote both funny and a little poignant. For generations, female visitors reportedly stuck pins into that codpiece in the belief it would improve their own fertility, a folk ritual performed on the armour of the most reproductively anxious monarch in English history, the man who broke with Rome and beheaded wives in pursuit of a son. The irony writes itself.

So give the Line of Kings a slow walk. It is layered like the building around it, a piece of Stuart spin, restaged by the Victorians, restaged again for us, still doing more or less what it was built to do. And in the middle of the pageant stands the actual steel that actually enclosed Henry the Eighth, dented, gleaming, and very slightly ridiculous, which is to say entirely true to the man.

The Crown Jewels: Regalia, Destruction and Rebirth

Almost nothing you'll see in the Jewel House predates 1660, and the reason is the most radical act in English history: after executing Charles the First in 1649, Cromwell's Commonwealth ordered the medieval regalia "totally broken," the gold melted for coin, the gems sold off. What you see is the replacement set made for Charles the Second's coronation in 1661, still in working use — this is a functioning collection, not a museum one. Three highlights reward a closer look. St Edward's Crown, the massive gold coronation crown, was used to crown Charles the Third in 2023; at over two kilograms, monarchs wear it only for the moment of crowning. The Sovereign's Sceptre holds Cullinan One, at 530 carats the largest clear-cut diamond in the world, cut from the 3,106-carat Cullinan rough found in South Africa in 1905 — famously sent to London by registered post while a decoy crossed on a guarded ship. And the Imperial State Crown contains layers of contested history: the Black Prince's Ruby (actually a spinel, reputedly worn by Henry the Fifth at Agincourt) and St Edward's Sapphire, said to come from a ring of Edward the Confessor, who died in 1066. The moving walkway, by the way, was installed after the collection's popularity made contemplative loitering a crowd-control problem.

Related listening: England's Crown Jewels and Scotland's older Honours, each with its own famous heist story. Coming up — "The Honours and the Stone: Objects of State" (Edinburgh Castle, Day 9).

Colonel Blood's Impossible Heist

The children's version of this room mentions Colonel Blood in passing, but the full story deserves better, because it is the most audacious crime in the building's history and it very nearly worked. Thomas Blood was an Anglo-Irish adventurer, a serial plotter and self-appointed colonel who had already tried to kidnap a duke. In 1671 he set his sights on the regalia itself.

His method was patience and charm, not force. Disguising himself as a mild country parson, with an accomplice posing as his wife, he cultivated a friendship with Talbot Edwards, the elderly Assistant Keeper of the Jewels, who for a small tip would show visitors the regalia privately. Over weeks Blood ingratiated himself so thoroughly that he proposed a marriage between Edwards's daughter and his fictional wealthy nephew. On the ninth of May he arrived with that nephew and two other men for a friendly viewing. The instant Edwards opened the chamber, they threw a cloak over his head, struck him with a mallet, and stabbed him.

Then came the improvisation. Blood flattened Saint Edward's Crown with the mallet to fit it under his cloak. An accomplice thrust the Sovereign's Orb down his breeches. The Sceptre was too long to conceal, so a third man set about sawing it in two. What undid them was the old keeper, who regained his senses and raised the alarm with astonishing lungs. In the scramble the sceptre was dropped, and Blood was seized near the wharf, the crushed crown still on him.

The epilogue is the genuinely mysterious part. Charged with treason, Blood refused to answer to anyone but the king, and Charles the Second, intrigued, granted him an audience. Rather than hanging, Blood walked away pardoned, his confiscated Irish estates restored, and an annual pension of five hundred pounds. Historians still argue about why. The kindest reading is that the Merry Monarch simply relished a rogue with style. The darker theories suppose Blood knew something, or someone, at court. Either way, the crown you see was flattened by a mallet within living memory of its making, and the man who did it died wealthy in his bed.

The Spoon That Survived

The most historically precious object in the Jewel House is also the least showy, and most visitors walk straight past it. Look for the Coronation Spoon, a slender gilt-silver anointing spoon, because it is the oldest thing in the room by a margin of nearly five centuries. It dates to the late twelfth century, probably made for Henry the Second or Richard the First, and it was already being described as a spoon of ancient form when it was first inventoried in 1349.

Its survival is the whole point. When Parliament abolished the monarchy and, in 1649, ordered the medieval regalia totally broken, the crowns were melted into Commonwealth coin and the gems dispersed. The destruction was near total, which is why the collection you see is essentially a Restoration reconstruction from 1661. Only a tiny handful of pieces slipped through, and just two survive complete from before the melting, the golden eagle-shaped Ampulla that holds the anointing oil, and this spoon. It endured because a former royal official, one of the very men organizing the sale of the dead king's goods, quietly bought it, and handed it back to Charles the Second after 1660, presumably hoping to be remembered kindly.

And it is not a relic under glass. It is working equipment. Anointing is the sacred heart of a British coronation, older and more solemn than the crowning itself, the moment screened from public view when holy oil is poured into this spoon and applied to the sovereign's head, breast, and hands. It performed that office for Charles the Third in 2023, an unbroken thread of ritual running back eight hundred years to the Plantagenets.

Keep one figure in mind as you glide past the crowns. The collection is set with twenty-three thousand, five hundred and seventy-eight gemstones across roughly a hundred and forty ceremonial objects, and it remains a living, functioning regalia, drawn on for coronations and the State Opening of Parliament rather than retired. The Cullinan diamonds can be unclipped and worn as brooches. The crowns are genuinely worn. You are not looking at the relics of monarchy. You are looking at its still-used toolkit, guarded here since the sixteen-sixties, with one small twelfth-century spoon at the bottom of it, older than the entire idea of the display.

The Ravens: An Invented Tradition That Became Real

The raven legend — that the kingdom falls if the ravens leave — feels ancient, but historians have traced it back no further than the late Victorian era; it may be a nineteenth-century romantic invention, possibly encouraged by the Gothic revival and Poe-era raven fashion. What’s genuinely interesting is how thoroughly an invented tradition has become institutional fact. The ravens are enlisted like soldiers: they can be, and have been, officially dismissed for conduct unbecoming — Raven George was discharged in 1986 for destroying TV aerials. During the Second World War, raven numbers dropped to one, a bird named Grip, and Churchill reportedly ordered the flock brought back up to strength. Today the Ravenmaster keeps at least six plus reserves, feeds them raw meat and blood-soaked biscuits, and trims flight feathers asymmetrically — enough to discourage long flights, not enough to ground them, and some do wander. The birds themselves out-perform the myth: corvids demonstrate tool use, planning, and facial recognition, and the Tower ravens have distinct personalities the warders discuss like colleagues. Merlina, the “queen of the ravens” until she disappeared in 2021, would play dead for tourists, lying on her back with feet in the air.

The Raven Cemetery and the Science of the Clever Bird

Tucked into the dry southern moat, near the Watergate, is a detail most visitors never find, the ravens’ cemetery, a modest plot with a memorial stone naming the Tower’s birds who have died in service since the nineteen-fifties. It is a small thing that tells you how seriously this fiction is taken. The birds are, in institutional terms, enlisted. They can be dismissed for misconduct, and when they die in post they are buried and named like old soldiers.

The living roster changes as birds retire or are lost, but the cast is always individual and always gossiped about. Beyond the famous names of the past, recent flocks have carried birds such as Poppy, Edgar, Georgie, and one inevitably christened Poe. The warders speak of them by temperament, because corvids genuinely have temperament, and the science behind that has grown startling.

Consider caching. A raven will hide surplus food and recall the locations for weeks, but the interesting part is the deception. In controlled studies, ravens that suspect they are being watched will make false caches, feigning a hiding place while palming the real morsel elsewhere, then relocating it once the audience leaves. That implies the bird models what a rival can and cannot see, a capacity we once reserved for primates. They also appear to plan ahead, selecting and saving a tool for a task minutes, or even a day, in the future.

Then there is the behavior that unsettles people most, the so-called raven funerals, in which corvids gather around a dead companion, and the play, birds sliding repeatedly down snowbanks or roofs for no reward but the sliding itself. Add vocal mimicry sharp enough that a Tower raven has greeted visitors with a guttural good morning, and the myth starts to look almost modest. We invented a story about these birds holding up the kingdom. The birds, it turns out, have been quietly running cognitive experiments on one another in the moat.

So watch them with the respect the warders do. The legend may be a Victorian invention, but the intelligence is real, ancient, and entirely their own, and the little headstone in the moat is where the Tower admits, quietly, that it has come to love them.

Scaffold Site and Traitors' Gate: The Political Prison

The Tower held surprisingly few prisoners at any one time — this was never a mass jail but a political one, reserved for people whose rank made them dangerous. That's what gives the roll call its weight: Anne Boleyn and Catherine Howard, queens of England; Thomas More; Lady Jane Grey, the sixteen-year-old “nine days' queen”; Walter Raleigh, who spent thirteen years here comfortably enough to write his *History of the World* and grow tobacco on the walls; Guy Fawkes, whose signature on his confession, before and after torture, deteriorates visibly. Executions on Tower Green, inside the walls, were a privilege of rank — only ten people died there, spared the mob on Tower Hill outside. Anne Boleyn's end in 1536 was distinctive: an expert swordsman was brought from Calais, and she was dead before most eyewitnesses registered the blow. The site's darkest mystery remains the Princes in the Tower, Edward the Fifth and Richard of York, last seen in 1483 as their uncle took the throne as Richard the Third. Bones found under a staircase in 1674 rest in Westminster Abbey; the Crown has so far declined DNA testing, so the case stays formally open. Pause at Traitors' Gate and consider that arriving through it, by water at low tide, was itself a piece of theatre — the state showing prisoners exactly how far they had fallen.

Related listening: Two of Henry's queens link these places: accused at Hampton Court, executed at the Tower. Coming up — “Ghost Stories as Compressed History” (Hampton Court Palace, Day 7).

The Last Executions at the Tower

The Tower's reputation for execution is medieval, but its actual record runs startlingly late, and the last chapter belongs to the twentieth century. The final person executed within these walls was not a Tudor grandee but a German agent named Josef Jakobs, shot by firing squad on the fifteenth of August, 1941. His story is almost slapstick in its misfortune. Parachuted into Huntingdonshire to radio intelligence back to Berlin, he broke his ankle on landing, could not move, and was arrested essentially where he fell. Because the fracture left him unable to stand, he was executed seated in a brown Windsor chair at the Tower's miniature rifle range, a small white target pinned over his heart, eight Scots Guards firing just after seven in the morning. He remains the last person ever put to death at the Tower.

Jakobs was the coda to a wartime pattern most visitors never learn. During the First World War, eleven German spies were tried and shot at that same rifle range between 1914 and 1916, the firing squad quietly resuming a function the block and axe had performed for centuries. The Tower had simply modernized its machinery of death.

For the older method's grand finale, go back to the ninth of April, 1747, and Simon Fraser, eleventh Lord Lovat, a wily Jacobite condemned for his part in the 1745 rising. His beheading on Tower Hill was the last public execution by axe in British history, and it turned into grim farce. So vast was the crowd that temporary timber galleries were thrown up for spectators, and one of them, dangerously overloaded, collapsed before the execution, killing around nine onlookers who had come precisely to watch someone else die. Told of the carnage, the seventy-nine-year-old Lovat was reportedly delighted, remarking that the more mischief, the better the sport, and he went to the block cracking jokes and quoting Horace. With his head fell the whole tradition. No one in Britain was ever judicially beheaded again.

So the roll of the condemned here does not end in velvet and ruffs. It ends with a firing squad, a broken-ankled spy in a borrowed chair, and the long ugly business finally, quietly, stopping.

The Ghosts of the Tower

A fortress with this much documented cruelty was always going to accumulate ghosts, and the Tower is routinely called the most haunted building in England. Approach the lore as folklore, not evidence, but do approach it, because the stories are unusually well recorded and the warders tell them beautifully.

Anne Boleyn leads the cast, as she does so much else here. Sightings of a woman in Tudor dress crossing Tower Green toward the Chapel of Saint Peter ad Vincula, where her bones actually lie, go back generations, sometimes embellished with the detail of the head carried under one arm. The best-documented account is Victorian. In 1864 a sentry was court-martialed for being found unconscious at his post and defended himself by swearing he had challenged a white figure that advanced straight through his bayonet, and, remarkably, other witnesses corroborated seeing something, and he was acquitted.

The Bloody Tower supplies the two small princes, Edward and Richard, whose disappearance you already know as history's mystery. Here they return as folklore, two child figures in white glimpsed hand in hand and then gone. And the Martin Tower gives the collection its genuinely strange set piece. In 1817 Edmund Lenthal Swifte, the Keeper of the Crown Jewels, recorded that while dining with his family a cylinder of glowing blue fluid drifted across the room and pressed toward his wife, who cried out that it was seizing her. Swifte was a sober, credible official who never recanted, and no one has convincingly explained what he described.

Round it out with the phantom bear said to have frightened a sentry to death near the Jewel House, a nod to the old menagerie, plus the usual repertoire of cold spots, footsteps, and the oppressive small hours in the Salt Tower, which dogs reportedly refuse to enter. None of it will survive a skeptic's cross-examination, and none of it needs to. The Tower's ghost stories are the emotional residue of its real history, the way a place this saturated with fear and grief goes on speaking after the documented facts run out. Linger as the gates close and the last light drains away, and you will understand exactly why people kept seeing things.

The Yeoman Warders and the Ceremony of the Keys

The Yeoman Warders date to 1485, formed under Henry the Seventh, which makes them among the oldest military corps in continuous existence. Entry requirements are real and strict: at least twenty-two years of military service, senior non-commissioned rank, and a Long Service and Good Conduct medal. Around thirty-five warders live inside the walls with their families — a village of roughly one hundred fifty residents with its own doctor, chaplain, and private pub, The Keys. In 2007, Moira Cameron became the first female Yeoman Warder in the corps' five-century history. The nickname Beefeater most likely derives from a ration of beef from the royal table, though competing etymologies keep the pub arguments alive. The Ceremony of the Keys, the nightly locking of the gates at 9:53 PM, has run essentially unbroken for around seven hundred years. The famous story from the Blitz is documented: on the twenty-ninth of December, 1940, a bomb blast knocked the escort off their feet mid-ceremony; they completed the locking-up and the Resident Governor wrote to the King apologizing for the delay. The Yeoman Warder tour you'll take is the oldest guided tour in the world by some reckonings — the warders have been showing visitors around, for tips, since the reign of Elizabeth the First.

Two Uniforms, Mistaken Identity, and a Barrel of Rum

Spend a moment on the uniform, because there are in fact two of them, and the difference is a small lesson in Tower history. What you will see today is the blue undress, a dark navy tunic with red facings, a soft Tudor bonnet, and the sovereign's cipher on the chest. It looks ancient but is the youngest thing here, introduced in the eighteen-fifties under Queen Victoria as a practical everyday alternative. The reason was money and misery. The alternative is the state dress, the sumptuous scarlet-and-gold outfit everyone pictures, whose design descends from around 1550, weighs a great deal, costs a fortune, and is reserved for coronations, state visits, and high ceremony. Victoria's household sensibly decided the warders needed something they could actually work in.

Now the pedantic point the warders will gently insist upon. The Yeoman Warders of the Tower are constantly confused with the Yeomen of the Guard, and the two are genuinely distinct bodies. The Yeomen of the Guard are the sovereign's personal ceremonial bodyguard, the oldest royal bodyguard in the world, and they, strictly, were the original Beefeaters. Their state dress is almost identical to the Warders', and the reliable way to tell them apart is the cross-belt worn over the left shoulder. The Guard wear it. The Warders of the Tower do not. Get it wrong within earshot of a Warder and you will be politely corrected.

For the connoisseur of odd survivals, there is the Ceremony of the Constable's Dues. In the days when the Constable of the Tower levied tolls on river traffic, vessels coming upstream paid a portion of their cargo. The custom endures in ceremonial form. When a Royal Navy ship berths at Tower Wharf, its captain must present the Constable with a barrel of wine, rum, or brandy, escorted in procession onto Tower Green by the Yeoman Warders and formally handed over. It is a genuine, still-performed transaction, a nine-hundred-year-old harbour due now paid in a cask of spirits. The Tower, in short, still collects rent on the Thames, and takes it neat.

One footnote for the drinks cabinet. The Beefeater on the gin bottle is a Yeoman Warder, a piece of borrowed prestige the brand has traded on for well over a century, with no official tie to the Tower at all.